

Readings

*To be deeply religious is
To have a passionate interest in the wholeness of existence,
To seek for the connecting tissue in the apparent separations,
To turn from disorder to seek the unity which lies hidden in diversity,
To pull hatred inside out and expose it as the shadow side of love,
To find no absolute end to the significance of life,
 not even in the event of death,
To seek to live less deformed and more gracious lives,
To have faith that at the center of it all is goodness
 and strength to empower us beyond our expectations,
And to turn our foolishness and evil into wisdom and beauty.*

Wallace W. Robbins, adapted

This church is not a place of right convictions, a fortress of truth or even a bastion of philosophy.

The church is a community of those who have suffered loss, lived through it, and learned true compassion.

We have a sense of awe and mystery about this world and this enterprise of living.

Our church is where we hear music and sing it ourselves, where we serve one another and the world, and where the strands of our beliefs, our lives and hopes are in a cable strong enough to bear us across the valleys of pain, despair, grief, doubt and disillusionment.

Each has experienced these, or will. We learn from each, and for these reasons we come to this special place, infusing it with hope.

W. Edwards Harris, adapted

VESSELS AND CABLES

If you have ever mentioned to your friends or acquaintances that you go to a Unitarian Universalist church, you have probably gotten a quizzical look and the standard question "What do they believe?" And if you are a visitor today, and new to this UU place of worship, you may be wondering the same thing.

Trying to explain what we are about as a church is a pretty difficult thing, because, in our western world, church is always linked to beliefs and creeds. It's especially confusing in the United States, because there are so many different church flavors. Every denomination has its own understanding of the truth. And people want to know what ours is.

So, how do we explain what we are, as a UU fellowship, and more particularly, what is it that this church, this congregation you have joined this morning, is all about? First, I will make it clear that I do not speak for your church. You folks have the task of describing yourselves. Secondly, I would like to mention as a theologian, that people devote years of study to the question "what is a church?" I, however, have about 20 minutes! However, I do have a few thoughts to pass on.

I like the passage I read to you earlier from W. Edward Harris. "This church is not a place of right convictions, a fortress of truth or even a bastion of philosophy." This is backward from everything most of us have been taught! Church is usually understood as somewhat of an elite club, where membership is predicated on one's acceptance of a pre-determined creed. It holds out "the Truth" and all who ascribe to it may belong.

But that is not us! We do not champion only one view of reality. We do not espouse only one set of doctrines. We do not claim to either explain or to defend the one truth. We are not the keepers of the Word. We do not possess the answers. Instead, we are a people of the questions.

Oddly enough, rather than being a place of absoluteness and security, we are a "community of those who have suffered loss, lived through it, and learned true compassion." Think of that. We are here, together, primarily because of what we have lost.

Now, most people have endured many losses. Loved ones, and health, finances, pets, and dreams. Grief seems to be the nature of being human. But all of us here have two losses in common, two losses that bind us into a community. Two losses that have made us into a church.

First, we lost "the Truth" (with a capitol T). We may have grown up in a faith tradition that offered us convictions about the world and the way of life and we may have held deeply to these teachings and creeds. Some of us may have always been the "unaligned gropers," never having entered a fortress of "correct beliefs." Yet, at some point, we lost. We lost the confidence that someone else could give us "the Truth."

For some, this was a devastating loss. It wrenched the world apart. There was no more certainty and no more black and white. For others, this was a freedom. They were no longer bound by the rules and opinions of others and they were pleased to be in a world of gray. We have each given up the illusion that another could provide us with an absolute and correct understanding of reality.

Yet, knowing that we are seekers after truth, rather than defenders of it, leads us to a second loss. Many people have decided that no institution can adequately define for them how the universe is. Many folks have no difficulty setting out on their own to establish a philosophy of living. But we do. We have lost the impression that we could do this alone. We are seekers of truth, and we claim questions, rather than answers. But we are clear that it is something we can't do well individually. We need each other. We have given up the concept of the Lone Ranger. Truth comes in community.

This church is not a stronghold housing and protecting our creeds. This is a vessel on which we travel, together, on our quest for understanding. It is a safe place where we can receive those who have suffered the same losses. We feel with them and we welcome

them.

We are also more than just a grief group, sharing our losses. And we are more than just an intellectual club, discussing various theories about life. "We have a sense of awe and mystery about this world and this enterprise of living." We are aware of the wholeness and wonder of it all. We are a religious people.

Listen to this definition by Wallace W. Robbins.

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and strength to empower us beyond our expectations,
And to turn our foolishness and evil into wisdom and beauty.

This is a passionate community. "We hear music and sing it ourselves." We don't just talk about life and truth, we are intensely participating in it, together.

Part of this living religiously means that we are a church of action. Because we have not divided the world into categories of those who have "the Truth" and those who do not, we have freed ourselves from the separations caused by such judgments. We can embrace the connections between us all. The earth is full of the "unity which lies hidden in diversity" and that leaves us with a responsibility. Of necessity, "We serve one another and the world."

As a church, we attend to each other. We do that in a number of ways. Perhaps the biggest is just that we continue to exist as a church. We provide a sheltered space for fellow truth seekers. Yet we also minister to each other in very practical ways. We accept and support; we listen and challenge; we humor and push, we bring casseroles and we hold hands. We are a warm, safe, and nurturing vessel.

And we reach out to our world. Again, our greatest contribution is our presence. Just the fact that we exist and thrive as a church without a creed makes an impact on our culture. We raise questions and we raise voices. Since we do not need to expend energy to defend doctrine, we are unfettered in our defense of the oppressed. Our sense of the wholeness of existence lends itself to service through social justice.

Still, we are more than a group of searchers after truth, who hold to the wonder of life and who give to each other and the world. We are a community. Our personal beliefs, our hopes, our very lives are entwined, forming a strong and beautiful cable.

You'll notice I said cable, not chain. Picture a chain in your mind. It is indeed a useful device. But we are all too aware that a chain is only as sturdy as its weakest link. If one link snaps, the chain is broken.

Now picture a cable, woven of various strands and coils. It is also useful and strong. But the cable is far sturdier than its weakest strand. If one strand snaps, or even if several break, in one spot, or in different places, the cable will still hold. It does not break.

That is how a community is. It is because we are braided together that we are stronger. Sometimes our own faith in the goodness at the center of it all may fail us. Sometimes we have misgivings about the significance of life. Sometimes we see no order and unity in the chaos. It is this cable that bears us "across the valleys of pain, despair, grief, doubt and disillusionment." Because it is at those times that we can borrow the faith of another. We can lean on someone else's passion. We can hang fast to other people's hope. And we can continue on.

Experience reminds us that living is not about believing right. It really isn't correct convictions. It's about loss and connection. It's about discovering the unity hidden in the diversity. It's about pulling hatred inside out and exposing the love. It's about creating less deformed and more gracious lives and turning our foolishness into wisdom.

We come to find that the church is not a fortress. It's a vessel. And it is not a chain, linking individuals. It is a cable, woven out of all of the strands of all of our lives.

It is because we learn these things from life and from each other that we come to this place, to this community, to this church, and we infuse it with hope.

Amen and Amen.